

CONEXIONES IN VENEZUELA: DR. SNIDER'S CROSS-CULTURAL EMPOWERMENT PEDAGOGY

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Abstract: In this piece, we share our reflections on Dr. Snider's teachings and curricular practices, including the importance of his cross-cultural empowerment pedagogy at a workshop in Venezuela. We ground our discussion in Paulo Freire's theoretical foundation as put forth in his *Pedagogy of the Oppressed* and discuss the ways Venezuelan students used Dr. Snider's debate lessons to protest oppressive conditions in Venezuela.

The country of Venezuela is in turmoil. Studies indicate that "nine out of 10 Venezuelans can no longer afford to buy enough food" because inflation is incredibly high (Hernández, 2016, para. 9). Thousands of people cannot afford health services, including medical supplies (Laurent, 2016). Ironically, the country has an overabundance of oil, which has often been cheaper than food and medical supplies. In addition, a huge divide exists between those that support the current President, Nicolás Maduro, those that long for the socialist ideals of former-President Hugo Chávez, and those that have long opposed Chávez and Maduro (Robins-Early, 2016). Conflict between different political groups has caused divisiveness in the country. As a result, countless protests have erupted, primarily targeted at the government's insufficient solutions to food scarcity and hunger. One of the protesting groups is the *Movimiento Estudiantil*, a student-led movement that organized with the intention of creating social reform.

In late 2008, we traveled to Venezuela to conduct a debate workshop. We had no idea what to expect from our visit. We had a romanticized idea of Chávez as a strong, passionate leader thanks to award winning documentaries, such as *The Revolution Will Not Be Televised*, and incomplete American media reports. We soon became aware of the social-political stratification present in the country. As soon as we landed in the Simón Bolívar International Airport, we visually saw a separation between the poor barrios that were divided by walls and roads from rich neighborhoods. Hundreds of compact, multi-colored houses crowded the hills near the airport; we would later learn that these crowded areas are enclosed, poor neighborhoods where poverty is rampant. Chávez's face was all over advertisements, billboards, and television because he was pushing for a constitutional reform to extend his reelection opportunities indefinitely. Newspapers described protests and activism by *La Oposición*, who sought to stop Chávez's reform, and stories of business owners who mistrusted Chávez's policies.

We soon met Dr. Snider, who was there to help us conduct the workshop. The purpose of the workshop was to teach Venezuelan university students to learn about debate and persuasion. The students' interest in debate stemmed from their desperation to overcome the deeply polarized political atmosphere in their country. Students' engagement in these workshops went beyond their interest to improve public speaking and argumentation skills. Rather, their interest was a deep and sincere yearning to promote public dialogue at a national level and help Venezuela move beyond divisiveness.

Prior to the workshop, our interaction with Dr. Snider was limited—we knew of him from our involvement in the intercollegiate policy debate

community in the United States. After the two-week workshop, we, including the students, faculty, and administrators from the Venezuelan universities, formed a very strong *conexión* and a shared vision to bolster public dialogue. Dr. Snider genuinely connected with all of us, despite our language differences (Spanish and English). He made possible a setting where we motivated each other to use debate as a tool against oppressive conditions, especially where freedom of speech and public dialogue were at risk.

In this piece, we share our reflections on Dr. Snider's teachings and curricular practices, including the importance of his cross-cultural empowerment pedagogy. We define cross-cultural empowerment pedagogy as an approach to teaching that adapts to students' different learning styles, needs, socio-economic backgrounds and cultures, as well as utilizes practical techniques that may effectively transform the realities of students outside of the classroom. Researchers have done extensive work on what is often referred to as culturally responsive teaching/pedagogy, an approach that adapts to the cultural differences and needs of students in different contexts (Gay 2002, 2010; Ikpeze, 2015; Kim & Slapac, 2015). We extend the concept of culturally responsive teaching/pedagogy to a cross-cultural context "where students work with others from diverse backgrounds [and] teachers help students view issues, concepts, and problems from multiple points of view, instead of from one dominant perspective" (Kim & Slapac, 2015, p. 19).

We ground our discussion in Paulo Freire's theoretical foundation as put forth in his *Pedagogy of the Oppressed* and discuss the ways Venezuelan students used Dr. Snider's debate knowledge to protest oppressive conditions. Cross-cultural empowerment pedagogy is consistent with Freire's recommendations

in *Pedagogy of the Oppressed* because, in essence, such pedagogy does not rely on top-down, traditional methods, is based on transformation against oppression, and educators adapt to the students' needs instead of their personal gains or interests. We hope that our experiences will inform readers in the intercollegiate debate community and beyond on how to develop and theorize about welcoming, adaptive, and reflexive debate pedagogy/curriculum in different international contexts. This is particularly vital knowing that debate can be a tool to fight conditions of social, political, and economic oppression, as was evidenced in Dr. Snider's lifelong mission to share debate across the world. After all, as communication agents-of-change, we carry a responsibility to evolve our practices to make our teaching practical, accessible, and ethical domestically and internationally.

Theoretical Foundation

In *Pedagogy of the Oppressed*, Paulo Freire (1970) discusses important recommendations for educators and students to collaboratively address oppressive social, political, and economic conditions. Although his original ideas about education have been criticized for focusing too much on class-based oppression and for failing to create broad social change, contemporary thinkers have shown that his recommendations are effective when used from an intersectional approach, as well as to empower students of color in contemporary classrooms (Dagron & Tufte, 2006; Denzin & Lincoln, 2008; hooks, 2014; Valdivia, 2008), including in international contexts (Rogers & Singhal, 2003).

Freire explains that truly revolutionary and liberatory education should not perpetuate a banking model of education, where a teacher merely deposits facts into students' minds, consequently making them

passive. Revolutionary education draws out students' creativity and agency by stimulating their own ideas, personal growth, and recommendations for social-political change. Educators have an obligation to guide students toward a conscious affirmation of their political agency and potential as active—not passive—agents in the world.

Freire argues that education should result in transformative praxis, particularly in places where urgent change is needed. Education that merely exists as theories and concepts in the classroom is a disservice to educators and students because such an approach stifles the transformative process. Educators and students benefit most from education that results in concrete social-political actions to address structural and ideological oppression.

Lastly, Freire argues that educators must actively challenge their privilege as educators and potential oppressors. Teachers have an obligation to suspend their preconceived beliefs and must immerse themselves in the cultures and lived realities of students. As such, teachers must suspend being teachers or objective decision-makers and adapt to the needs of students. Educators must stand along-side students to struggle with them and not superficially pretend to be above them.

Challenging the Banking Model of Education and Promoting Active Dialogue

Working with Dr. Snider was a transformative experience. To begin with, we had just received our Bachelor's degrees in the United States. We were aware that the workshops included graduate and undergraduate students that were close to our age, but were well into their academic careers. Many of the students had deep interests and academic aspirations in

economics and politics; several of them had previously enrolled in classes or summer institutes at Harvard or international universities. We were aware that they were deeply concerned about their country. We were extremely nervous because despite our experience in teaching debate to high school students and at summer debate institutes, the Venezuelan students were seeking our help to mobilize for transformation instead of winning tournaments. We were afraid of being unintentionally inauthentic; that because of the short timeframe we had, we would default to a top-down teaching model. We were nervous that we would be too linguistically and culturally different to truly form a strong *conexión* with the students.

With Dr. Snider's guidance, we built a curriculum that was centered on collaborative dialogue. This was a challenge because we only knew the skills and concepts taught in the U.S. policy debate arena. Our obligation was to make policy debate concepts accessible for the students who had little to no exposure to formal debate. Concepts such as "affirmative stock issues" or "negative disadvantages" and "counterplans" were unfamiliar and foreign to the students. Importantly, we faced the difficulty of translating English concepts, such as *uniqueness*, *links*, or *impacts* (terminology used for disadvantages), into Spanish in a manner that would capture what the concepts truly meant in the U.S. policy debate context. A lack of exposure to these technical terms and concepts combined with the linguistic translation inconsistencies made teaching across cultures very tedious and difficult. Dr. Snider encouraged us to simplify those arguments to show the possibilities of their utility, and to apply them to describe problems, causes for those problems, and solutions. Additionally, Dr. Snider encouraged us to learn the governmental processes, culture, and

social realities of Venezuela from the students. We learned about opposing viewpoints from different political groups as we did research with the students. We focused on understanding multiple perspectives, including those of oppositional groups, to better understand persuasive techniques to overcome divisive dialogue.

The research strategies and learning activities focused on current events in Venezuela. This was out of our comfort zone because we were more familiar with current events pertinent to the U.S. As a result, Dr. Snider pushed us to adapt and learn about the country and students' lives. The intention was not to train students for intensive competition. On the contrary, the point of the workshop was to share with students how to formally introduce arguments, follow logical structure, and avoid fallacious reasoning in public settings. These skills would facilitate students' application of debate theories, persuasion, and skills to address problems in the status quo.

Education for Praxis

An important lesson that Dr. Snider explained to us was that the debate workshop should heed to the student's needs. These young professionals joined these workshops not for academic stimulation, but to respond to the paralyzed and fragmented dialogue plaguing the country at the level of government, media, and the streets. Why else would they participate in an intensive two-week workshop that did not result in university units or credits whatsoever? These students had jobs and families to protect, theses and projects to finish, and exams to prepare for. Time was absolutely of the essence for them.

The students' desire was to promulgate amongst their communities what we often refer to in policy

debate as the burden of rejoinder. The burden of rejoinder refers to the effective refutation of arguments after critically listening, understanding, and evaluating their claims, evidence, and/or reasoning. In Venezuela, oppositional groups often did not entertain the idea of understanding each other to prove each other wrong. Ideological divide prevented groups from truly listening to each other, much less rebut each other's arguments through effective argumentation. Hence, the students discovered that the burden of rejoinder in practice would allow opposing groups to critically listen to understand each other and, ideally, open the door for productive civil dialogue.

We learned from the students that the predominant ideals in U.S. policy debate did not fit their cultural context. For example, we learned that the traditional framework in U.S. policy debate, which is centered on federal government legislative processes, the system of checks and balances, and representative democracy, was not responsive to the changes they wanted. The students indicated that focusing on understanding the Venezuelan government structure felt disingenuous because the political reality was such that *La Oposición* was locked out of government processes. *Chávistas*, Chávez supporters and his administration, were the principal decision-makers. Since a large part of the population felt blocked off and unable to access these structures, the traditional framework in U.S. policy debate was not empowering. Instead, the students wanted to learn about persuasive methods in resistance social movements. As such, we shifted our assumptions about governmental legislative action to reflect those of the Venezuelan grassroots reality. We shifted our attention to how students could persuade people in local environments to protest, empower each other, and seek grassroots activism to change the political system.

Weeks after the workshop, we received notice that several of the workshop participants became highly active in the *Movimiento Estudiantil Venezolano*, or *Movimiento Estudiantil*. The *Movimiento Estudiantil* is a national, collective student movement that started organizing as far back as 2007 and focused on increasing social consciousness, activism, and proposing local and alternative initiatives for change (Ivancheva, 2015). Initially, the goal of the movement was to protect “freedom of expression,” but they broadened their goals to “include a wide range of rights, hoping to overcome the country’s polarization” (Orozco, 2008, para. 17). Although many critics of the movement saw it as a pro-democracy, pro-U.S., and middle-class based movement, the group became a national phenomenon promoting values such as public deliberation and transformation (Ivancheva, 2015; Orozco, 2008). The student activists, including those that participated in our workshop, were part of the majority that voted to prevent Chávez’s constitutional reform to extend his reelection indefinitely.

Challenging the Teacher’s Privilege by Seeking *Conexiones*

Beyond encouraging us to make our curriculum applicable to students’ lives, Dr. Snider pushed us to engage in an ongoing cultural exchange of values and experiences. Dr. Snider genuinely attempted to know the culture, students, and lived realities of the people of Venezuela. He encouraged and inspired us to immerse ourselves into the cultures of the students, as well. We visited students’ homes, their neighborhoods, and local restaurants. The students welcomed us with open arms, which allowed us to form a strong *conexión* with the students.

From the students, we learned and heard about the

complicated tensions and stratification of the country. Most frustrating to them was the government's position to squander anti-*Chávista* dialogue or movements. Government fear of anti-*Chávistas* hindered the everyday freedoms of Venezuelan citizens. At one point, we visited a closed upper-middle class apartment community to visit one of our students. When we were leaving the community, government *federales* stopped our car, searched our belongings, and interrogated us for being in the country. The *federales* searched us to ensure that we were not drug dealers or criminals. This, according to the students, was common occurrence and a result of *federales'* need to exercise dominance in anti-*Chávista* communities. This was the reality that many people who oppose *Chávista* ideals faced in Venezuela. This was a true limitation to freedom of ideology and speech.

In addition, we were exposed to our privilege as members of the intercollegiate competitive U.S. policy debate community. The students were fascinated at the fact that students in the U.S. participated in debate often solely for sport or to jumpstart their academic and professional careers. Debate was neither a sport nor a venue to start a career for the workshop students. To learn debate was their civic duty because it carried in them an obligation to improve their community and spark a bottom-up democratization. Consequently, our collaboration with students was entirely based on a collaborative process where we, junior educators, became students and the students became our educators.

The friendly relationships we formed with students were genuine, which is why we learned to trust each other and built a strong bond—*conexión*—which transcended the learning classroom and debate pedagogy. These *conexiones* were developed in

ephemeral moments and fostered by our willingness to actively engage and listen to each other. These *conexiones* developed when we sat down for lunch and listened to their concerns about the country's future, or shared our hobbies and projects while eating dinner at their favorite restaurants, or listened to their aspirations and goals over coffee. These *conexiones* also occurred in the classroom and practice debates where they explained their stories. In all these contexts, we connected with them both outside and inside the workshops to show that we were interested in who they were as people. This was important for the success of the workshop. In a cross-cultural context, our cultures often have a sharpened skill and emotive-cognitive ability to sense authenticity and genuineness, especially from White outsiders. If we sense good intentions and if we *feel* genuine care from outsiders, we may immediately establish a heart-felt *conexión*. In a sociopolitical sense, *conexión* is juxtaposed to opposition or competition. *Conexión*, relationally, is a process—immediate and otherwise—where individuals form a profound connection and emotive linkage that transcends social, political, or economic circumstance. Through this relational connection, individuals may arise the intent of collaborating to transform reality.

Conclusion

Dr. Snider was an exemplary educator that embodied the Freirean spirit of empowerment, liberation, and revolutionary dialogue. We were fortunate that he helped us devise a curriculum that spurred the necessary dialogue for us to translate policy debate concepts to the lived realities of Venezuelan students. Traditionalists often argue that there are important, beneficial, and vital pedagogical possibilities in the U.S. style policy format. We do not entirely disagree with this. Many students and

countries adapt to this style and use the curriculum to advance their self-empowerment. However, Andrade and Bruschke (2015) argued that a traditionalist, one-size-fits-all framework for teaching debate maintains an authoritative power that may demotivate students, as well as squelch different cultural forms of knowledge. The principal lesson is that a one-size model of education, including the banking system or a strict traditional policy debate model, runs the risk of alienating students. A top-down government centered approach leaves little room for students who do not identify or feel empowered by such solutions, making their experiences and background feel irrelevant. In the lessons learned from the Venezuela workshops, we had to change the curriculum to adapt to the knowledge base, needs, and realities of students.

During the entire workshop, Dr. Snider stepped aside and trusted us and the students to conduct a revolutionary workshop. He allowed this to happen organically. In a truly Freirean sense, Dr. Snider stood behind us and the students because he did not want to speak for us, through us, or above us. This world needs more educators like Dr. Snider who are willing to entrust in others the ability to create revolutionary education in learning spaces and politically contentious environments like Venezuela, as well as to genuinely seek *conexiones* with others. Que en paz descanse, Dr. Snider.

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